after the incumbent MLAs contested and won the LS polls; the Sishamau seat fell vacant after the SP MLA, Irfan Solanki, was disqualified.

SP chief Akhilesh Yadav is engaged in expanding his successful 'PDA (Pichhda-Dalit-Alpasankhyak)' strategy. The new segment the party wants to add to its rainbow of OBCs, SCs and minorities (read Muslim) are the Brahmins. Recently, Akhilesh appointed the SP's veteran Brahmin face, Mata Prasad Pandey, 81, as leader of the Opposition in the UP assembly. SP insiders say this is a "forward looking" move, with the 2027 assembly election in mind, when the party will be fighting a "Thakur CM". In eastern UP, Thakurs and Brahmins have an old rivalry and if Akhilesh's 'PDA Plus' pans out, it could be a big challenge for the NDA in the state.

The SP had already experimented with a wider social base in the Lok Sabha polls, going beyond its traditional M-Y (Muslim-Yadav) votebank. Of its 62 candidates, only five were Yadavs (all from Akhilesh's Saifai family) and four were Muslims. Back in May, signalling a new warmth towards non-Yadav OBCs, the SP had appointed Shyamlal Pal, an OBC from the Pal community, as state president. Talking to INDIA TODAY, Akhilesh described his caste perestroika as part of his intent to "raise the voice of 90 per cent of the population. Our PDA includes everyone. Now the BJP is running scared because we are expanding. We will defeat them in the bypolls too".

Meanwhile, the BJP's internal crisis has taken on the contours of a near-rebellion. Yogi's spat with his deputy CMs, Keshav Maurya and Brajesh Pathak, is already the talk of the town in Lucknow. The high command has met all the players involved but was unable to extract a lasting solution. For now, the CM and his deputies have been told to keep the peace and concentrate on winning the bypolls.

Among the seats going to the polls, Karhal in Mainpuri (which Akhilesh vacated) and Milkipur in Faizabad (Ayodhya) will be prestige battles for the SP. The party's Awadhesh Prasad used to be the Milkipur MLA and his shock LS win in the temple town had rocked the BJP. Ghaziabad Sadar and Khair will be the sure seats for the BJP, while Phulpur should see a tough fight (where the SP candidate lost the seat by just 4,000-odd votes).

In his seven years as chief minister, Yogi has never faced a challenge to his power; an unfavourable result in the bypolls could change that. Already, the antagonist section within the state BJP is blaming him for the LS reverses, claiming that the OBCs and Dalits are drifting away from the party because of "the upper caste CM". Everyone is watching to see how Yogi will fare in what is his first big crisis. The next assembly poll, in 2027, is too distant for this to qualify as a "semi-final", but the stakes are surely as high. ■

VOTING SLIP



↘ The losses in the LS polls have put pressure on the BJP and CM Yogi Adityanath to perform well in the UP bypolls

↘ SP is on the ascendant and feels that a good show in the bypolls will put them ahead for the 2027 assembly poll

↘ Akhilesh is expanding the party's 'PDA Plus' strategy; its new LoP is a Brahmin



It is not every day that the Supreme Court, especially the bench of the Chief Justice of India, finds itself "disturbed" by a status report filed by an investigating agency. But the rape-and-murder case of a junior doctor at the state-run RG Kar Medical College and Hospital (RGKMCH) in Kolkata moved even CJI D.Y. Chandrachud into imagining the worst. While hearing the matter on September 17, he said: "What the CBI has revealed in the report is worse, really disturbing...we ourselves are concerned." Chandrachud said the CBI is probing if the crime scene has been tampered with, whether evidence was destroyed, whether there was complicity of other people in the crime as well as financial irregularities at RGKMCH. The CJI said that the investigating agency must be given more time to "unearth the absolute truth". The overall optics has brought no redeeming touch for the state government yet. The court rebuked it even for suggesting limited work hours for women and limiting night duties for them "to the extent possible". "They (women) don't want a concession... women are ready to work at exactly the same time shift," the CJI observed. Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for West Bengal, agreed to do away with these suggestions. Indira Jaising, the counsel for the striking doctors—who are now leading the movement for jus-